

The Eight Conversations Checklist

From Married to the Mission: A Relationship Guide for the New Military Spouse

DO TOGETHER — BEFORE THE WEDDING

Check each conversation you have had. For any you haven't, schedule a time before the wedding or ceremony. These conversations don't have to be resolved — they have to be started.

☐ The PCS conversation: Am I genuinely willing to follow wherever the military sends us? What does "genuinely willing" mean for me in practice?

☐ The career sacrifice conversation: Whose career takes precedence? Who is responsible for protecting the other partner's professional identity across moves?

☐ The children conversation: Who parents during deployment? What is our plan when the plan falls through?

☐ The financial conversation: Does the civilian partner have independent financial access and identity?

☐ The fidelity and deployment conversation: Have we said our expectations out loud, not just assumed them?

☐ The attachment conversation: Do I know how I respond when I feel emotionally unsafe? Does my partner know?

☐ The identity conversation: Who am I outside of this relationship? How will I protect that person inside military life?

☐ The institution conversation: Can I finish this sentence honestly —
"When the military takes precedence over our family, I will feel ___ and I
will handle it by ___"?

Isaiah and Zoe checked zero of these boxes. If you've checked fewer than four,
make a date — not a fight — to work through the rest before the ceremony.